

dorf, Germany, where she spent 18 years of her life. She was surrounded by friends who used to bake Sonntagsfrühstück, or ‘Sunday breakfast’, which typically involves a leisurely breakfast, often featuring a variety of fresh bread rolls. Intrigued by the German tradition of baking, she learned this new skill on her own, much like how she learnt the German language by watching movies.

“Although I have never formally taken a baking course, my journey began in Germany, where I learnt from my friends and explored online resources. Instagram and YouTube have been invaluable tools. The trial-and-error approach has been quite

the art of making the best sourdough bread!”

She happily shares two golden rules when it comes to baking: Follow rules, but feel free to improvise. Failure is a learning experience. She says, “I usually stick to a recipe when cooking because I love trying out new dishes. Some things, like baking, need to be precise with measurements. But many recipes are flexible. I’ll skip ingredients I don’t like or substitute if I’m missing something. I don’t completely wing it, though—I keep the basic recipe in mind. It’s all about having a plan but being adaptable. That’s pretty much how I live my life too: I have a structure, but I adjust

I overdid it. You get better with practice and with the right tools.”

Gangadharan loves baking by hand, with music playing in the background, as she says it can be quite calming. “The process sneaks in under your skin and fills your head with thoughts. The thoughts drift as you knead and knead and knead. Soon, your mind is quiet. I find it quite rejuvenating.” For Gangadharan, baking is also therapeutic, providing a sense of calm and mindfulness. She loves the fact that it brings out her creative side, allowing her to play around with recipes, flavours, and decorations. “I have also found the simple joy of creating and enjoy-

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useful... it has further helped me understand the nuances and develop my unique style,” she says.

The art of baking has stayed with her even after her return to Bengaluru, where she bakes on some weekends for her daughters, as well as her team. “This is usually a combination of classics like Elisenlebkuchen (German gingerbread cookies) and Aachener Poschweck (sweet loaf), and some interesting new recipes I come across on Instagram.” She has even mastered the art of making her own yeast. “During lockdown, I started with my first jar of sourdough starter and now I can proudly state that I have cracked

when needed.”

She also shares that she has perfected the preparations down to a science. But there are some things that she continues to learn. A few weeks back, she made macarons for the first time. “[It was a] total failure. I left out an important ingredient. I made a second batch a few days ago. [It was] much better, but still not quite right. I have a third batch planned next week. When you fail, you learn something and plan your next try accordingly.”

Gangadharan also makes notes about the things that didn’t work. “If I overcook something, I’ll jot down how much I think

ing something delicious to be greatly satisfying at the end of a very busy work week. Most importantly, baking helps me stay in the present moment as it requires a lot of focus and attention to detail, much like my work.”

When asked if she ever wants to transform her hobby of baking into a profession, pat comes her reply that she prefers keeping it as a beloved pastime. The freedom to experiment, lack of pressure, and the pleasure of sharing homemade treats with her loved ones is what makes baking a thing of joy for Gangadharan. **BT**

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